

Brussels, where I had one of the best days of my life. I met a family there that paid for all my food and let me hang out with them—a twelve-person midwestern family of teenagers and middle-aged adults who bought me waffles and chocolate and mussels and pasta and beer. One of the women told me, “We’d hope your parents would do that for one of our kids if the situation was reversed.”

I had a great time in Madrid, where I stayed with my friend who lives there. The song “Call Me Maybe” had just come out, and every nightclub we partied at played nothing else. I got too drunk, made out with some dude while a Spanish cover band butchered the Red Hot Chili Peppers’ “Dani California,” and did not sleep for three days. In terms of money, I may as well have just opened a suitcase of it and let it fly out into the Grand Canyon. I started to put everything on my credit card, which had a \$5,000 limit that had already been tested with my unnecessary lip surgery. I wrote this in my journal:

So stupid and unanticipated to be in Paris and to be lonely. I often feel alone in New York but not like this. Had that sense again of “Wherever you go, there you are” in that traveling somewhere else doesn’t mean you can escape yourself. It’s not the city that makes the difference. Not that getting to see and understand the endless, overwhelming world isn’t helpful or that I don’t appreciate how beautiful everything is and how lucky I am to finally be doing this—since I often feel this weird weight about not being able to experience everything that’s out there. But at the same time, it’d be better with people. I thought going on this trip would cure my depression or instantly make me a better, more well-rounded person, but that’s not the case. It’s not traveling; it’s human interaction—from the Ozarks to Japan to Canada to wherever you go—it’s having other people around to share what you’re doing. Someone once wrote on one of my Thought Catalog articles, “If everyone feels alone, why can’t we all just find each other?” I don’t know if it’s that easy, but I do know now that I have to be okay where I am, before I can be okay anywhere else.

I was starting to get it, but my behavior was not going to catch up just yet.